

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

ISSUE	ATB-2026-14
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DOMINANT JUDGMENT	RETALIATION CAMPAIGN CONFIRMED ACTIVE

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Executive Warning: This week’s shift is from assessed risk to confirmed activity. A U.S.-Iran framework agreement may be signed this weekend, but the wider conflict is not resolved — Israeli forces continued heavy strikes in Lebanon through 13 June, and Tehran has tied any final agreement to a Lebanon ceasefire that Israel has not committed to. Independent of that diplomatic track, the Iran-aligned proxy Handala executed and publicly confirmed a retaliatory cyber operation against California Water Service on 11–12 June — accessing a customer billing database and an internal GPS-correction network across multiple service districts, explicitly framed as payback for U.S. strikes on Iranian water infrastructure. No water-delivery or control-system compromise was found, but Handala claimed it could have disrupted service and chose not to. Texas Gulf Coast energy and water operators were not targeted this week, but share the same exposure profile under the federally confirmed AA26-097A PLC campaign. **The decision risk: treating the California incident as an isolated story rather than the opening move of an active campaign with a documented pattern of claim-then-escalate.**

Board Implications This Week — Ask

Which dependency pivot exists in our environment? Handala’s confirmed attack chain moved from a GPS-correction/survey platform into a customer billing system. Identify the equivalent pivot path in your own IT/operational-support architecture before an adversary finds it for you.

Board Implications This Week — Direct

Require confirmation this week of two items: no internet-exposed Rockwell/Allen-Bradley PLCs per AA26-097A, and the remediation status of Check Point CVE-2026-50751 on any IKEv1 VPN or Spark Firewall.

Board Implications This Week — Document

If a segmentation gap or unpatched edge device is found and not yet remediated, record that as a board-level risk-acceptance decision now — not after the next incident.

Board Implications This Week — Rehearse

Run a 60-minute tabletop using the Cal Water attack chain as the scenario: GPS/survey-network access pivoting into customer billing. Identify your equivalent pivot point and who owns the response.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

We assess with High confidence that an Iran-aligned proxy retaliatory cyber campaign against U.S. critical infrastructure is now active — not merely anticipated — and with Moderate confidence that it is likely to escalate toward operational-technology targeting or extend to additional U.S. water and energy operators, including Texas Gulf Coast assets, over the next 1–4 weeks, regardless of the outcome of the U.S.-Iran diplomatic track.

Confirmed: California Water Service stated it conducted a preliminary scan of its internal IT and OT networks and found no signs of compromise to IT, water production, or delivery systems, with the investigation ongoing. Independent technical analysis confirmed the breach was limited to a GPS correction server and a customer billing database, with no evidence of compromise to operational technology or industrial control systems. Cal Water's Chico district was confirmed as the access point, with the compromised GPS-correction platform having been operational for roughly 783 hours and streaming correction data across all seven identified district mountpoints before access.

Attribution and framing: Handala presents publicly as a pro-Palestinian hacktivist group but is widely assessed as a front for Iran-backed Void Manticore, active since at least December 2023, and has significantly escalated U.S.-targeted operations since February 2026. Water infrastructure fits its doctrine of targeting “life-sustaining” systems for psychological effect. The group published its claim under the banner “From Sirik to California: Handala Hits Back at America’s Water,” explicitly referencing Stuxnet and warning that future actions against Iranian interests would draw further attacks on U.S. infrastructure.

Bottom line: This confirms — rather than merely supports — the retaliation thesis carried in ATB-2026-13. The remaining uncertainty is scope: whether this stays at the access/exfiltration level seen in California, or whether Handala (or another Iran-aligned proxy) follows its documented escalation pattern toward OT/ICS targeting. No Texas-specific targeting is in evidence, but a MOIS-linked proxy operating on its own retaliation timeline is not bound by the broader negotiation — Handala’s stated trigger (U.S. strikes on Iranian water infrastructure) is independent of any U.S.-Iran framework agreement.

Section I

What Changed This Week

Handala Confirms Active Retaliatory Campaign Against a U.S. Water Utility

On **11–12 June 2026**, the Iran-linked group Handala publicly claimed it had compromised California Water Service (Cal Water), one of the largest investor-owned water utilities in the U.S., and published a 5GB data dump including customer billing records and administrative credentials for an internal GPS-correction (RTKBase/NTRIP) network spanning multiple service districts. Cal Water stated a preliminary scan of its IT and OT networks found no signs of compromise to water production or delivery systems; the investigation continues. Independent technical analysis confirmed access was limited to the GPS-correction server and the billing database, with no evidence reaching ICS/SCADA. This is the clearest evidence to date that the Iran-aligned retaliation campaign anticipated in prior issues is operational now — not a future contingency.

U.S.-Iran Framework Agreement Reported, Lebanon Front Remains Active

Reporting indicates the U.S. and Iran have agreed on the text of a framework agreement, with a possible signing this weekend. However, **Israeli strikes in Lebanon continued through 13 June**, killing several

people, and Tehran has stated any final agreement must include a Lebanon ceasefire — a condition Israel's defense minister has not accepted. The decision-relevant point: a state-to-state framework agreement does not necessarily bind Iran-aligned proxies operating on independent retaliation timelines, as the Cal Water incident demonstrates.

China-Linked JDY Reconnaissance Botnet Scaling Rapidly — DIB-Relevant

Lumen's Black Lotus Labs reports the JDY botnet — a China-nexus reconnaissance network linked to Volt Typhoon — has more than doubled from roughly 650 compromised devices in January 2024 to over 1,500 today, diversifying from two Cisco router models to seven device manufacturers. The botnet was observed scanning Fortinet equipment within hours of a new vulnerability's April 2026 disclosure. Its scanning shows a clear focus on U.S. military and associated-entity networks, with other sectors scanned at lower, unspecified volume. This is secondary-sourced vendor research, not confirmed against Texas energy, finance, or healthcare — but it is directly relevant to Texas defense-industrial-base contractors as “associated entities,” and the scaling velocity is the headline concern regardless of sector specificity.

Check Point VPN Authentication-Bypass Flaw Added to KEV Catalog

On **8 June 2026**, CISA added Check Point Security Gateway improper-authentication vulnerability CVE-2026-50751 to its Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog. Per industry reporting, the flaw has been exploited since early May, affects Mobile Access/SSL and Remote Access VPNs and Spark Firewalls running deprecated IKEv1, and has been linked to Qilin ransomware in at least one case. This is a same-week patch-and-audit item on its own timeline — but a compromised VPN edge is also the kind of access point an Iran-aligned proxy could exploit opportunistically during this heightened-tension window.

Section II

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses with **high confidence** that an Iran-aligned proxy retaliatory cyber campaign against U.S. critical infrastructure is now **active and confirmed**, not merely anticipated. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: California Water Service's 12 June statement confirming a preliminary IT/OT scan found no compromise to production or delivery systems; independent technical analysis confirming access to a GPS-correction server and billing database; Handala's public claim explicitly framing the operation as retaliation for U.S. strikes on Iranian water infrastructure. Primary uncertainty: the full scope of data accessed and whether other Cal Water districts beyond Chico were affected remains under investigation.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Treat this as confirmation that the threat model is live, not theoretical. Water, energy, and utility operators should move segmentation and OT-exposure reviews from “assessment backlog” to “this week.”

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that this campaign escalates toward operational-technology targeting or extends to additional U.S. water/energy operators — including Texas Gulf Coast assets — over the next 1–4 weeks, independent of the U.S.-Iran diplomatic track. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Handala's documented pattern of initial claims followed by escalated action (March 2026 Stryker wiper attack); the group's explicit statement that it could have disrupted water service

and chose restraint as a “warning”; the standing AA26-097A PLC campaign already covering energy and water. Primary uncertainty: whether a possible U.S.-Iran framework agreement reduces proxy incentive, or whether MOIS-linked proxies operate independent of that track as the Cal Water timing suggests.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas Gulf Coast energy and water operators should not wait for a Texas-named victim. The segmentation pattern exploited at Cal Water (field-operations/survey network pivoting to billing) is broadly replicable.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses with **high confidence** that China-linked reconnaissance infrastructure (the JDY botnet) is scaling rapidly and operationalizing newly disclosed vulnerabilities within hours — a DIB-relevant access-development risk for Texas defense contractors as “associated entities” of its primary military targeting focus. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Lumen Black Lotus Labs primary research (10 June 2026) documenting growth from ~650 to 1,500+ devices since January 2024 and a selective post-disclosure scanning spike against Fortinet equipment. Primary uncertainty: Lumen’s report does not name energy, finance, or healthcare as targeted sectors — this remains a DIB-framed implication, not a general Texas cross-sector claim.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas DIB-classified or military-adjacent contractors should review edge-device (router/firewall/IoT) inventory and patch cadence given the “hours after disclosure” targeting pattern.

Section III

Geopolitical Driver

The strategic driver this week is the divergence between state-to-state diplomacy and proxy-actor retaliation timelines. A U.S.-Iran framework agreement may reduce the incentive for direct Iranian state cyber operations, but Handala — widely assessed as a front for Iran-backed Void Manticore — operates on its own retaliation cycle, triggered by specific kinetic events (the Sirik water-infrastructure strikes) rather than the overall negotiation status. Separately, China-nexus reconnaissance (JDY/Volt Typhoon) continues its long-running pattern of crisis pre-positioning against U.S. military and associated-entity networks, unrelated to the Iran conflict. Texas matters because its energy, water, finance, healthcare, and DIB sectors sit inside both threat pictures: the confirmed Iran-proxy retaliation pattern (water/energy exposure via AA26-097A and the Cal Water precedent) and the DIB-relevant China reconnaissance pattern (defense contractors as “associated entities”).

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Continuum assessment: The Iran-proxy retaliation campaign has moved from **competition** to an active **crisis-response** posture — a real (if contained) attack has occurred. Texas Gulf Coast energy and water operators should treat the next 1–4 weeks as a heightened threat window for the segmentation pattern demonstrated against Cal Water, independent of how the U.S.-Iran diplomatic track resolves.

Section IV

Why This Matters to Texas

This week converts an assessed risk into a demonstrated attack chain: a field-operations/survey network (GPS correction) pivoting into a customer-facing billing system, executed by an Iran-aligned proxy explicitly retaliating for U.S. military action. Texas energy and water operators with comparable IT/operational-support architectures — and there are many — now have a concrete pattern to test against their own environments, not a hypothetical. Layer in the standing AA26-097A PLC campaign, the active Check Point VPN exploitation, and JDY’s DIB-relevant reconnaissance scaling, and the board-level question is no longer whether Texas is in the targeting set. It is whether the specific pivot path used against Cal Water exists, unaudited, inside Texas energy and water operators today.

Cross-Sector Cascade Assessment

Energy / Water ERCOT / OT / Gulf Coast	What changed: The confirmed Handala/Cal Water attack chain — pivot from a GPS-correction/survey platform into a customer billing system — is a segmentation failure pattern, not an OT-specific exploit, meaning it is broadly replicable at any utility with similar architecture. Why it matters locally: Combined with AA26-097A’s standing finding that an Iranian-affiliated APT has been disrupting internet-exposed Rockwell/Allen-Bradley PLCs and manipulating HMI/SCADA displays across energy, water, and government-services sectors, Texas Gulf Coast operators face two converging risks: the confirmed proxy access/exfiltration pattern, and the standing OT-disruption campaign. Cascade risk: ERCOT summer-peak fragility (carried from ATB-2026-13) means any OT disruption during peak demand has materially worse consequences across healthcare, water, and fuel logistics.
Financial Availability / Edge Exposure	What changed: FINRA’s standing warning that Iranian state-sponsored and aligned actors retain capability and intent for disruptive operations is now substantiated by a real, if contained, event. Separately, CISA added Check Point CVE-2026-50751 (IKEv1 authentication bypass, exploited since early May, linked to Qilin ransomware) to its KEV catalog on 8 June. Cascade risk: Same-week patch item on its own timeline — but a compromised VPN edge is exactly the kind of opportunistic access point an Iran-aligned proxy could exploit during this heightened-tension window.
Healthcare / DIB / AI Pattern Continuity / Access Governance	Healthcare: Handala’s most significant prior operation was the March 2026 wiper attack on medical device maker Stryker. The Cal Water incident confirms this actor remains active and capable against U.S. targets — not a closed chapter for Texas medtech and hospital systems dependent on similar vendors. DIB: The JDY botnet’s scaling (650→1,500+ devices, hours-after-disclosure targeting, primary focus on U.S. military and associated entities) is a secondary-sourced but directly relevant warning for Texas defense contractors. AI/Tech: Per vendor reporting (moderate confidence), North Korea’s Famous Chollima and UNK_DeadDrop continue AI-enabled fake IT-worker and developer-phishing operations against U.S. tech firms, raising hiring and code-repository access risk. Cascade risk: A destructive healthcare event compounds with the same water/energy retaliation pattern if both occur during a degraded-grid scenario.

Section V

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 5 / I&W 1 Cal Water investigation outcome — OT/ICS access confirmation or denial [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch for Cal Water or federal investigators confirming (or ruling out) any access to operational technology or industrial control systems beyond the billing/GPS-correction systems already confirmed.
- Would determine whether this campaign has crossed from data access to control-system exposure — a direct escalation signal.
- Tied to: PIR 5, strategic vulnerability exposure across critical infrastructure.

PIR 1 / I&W 2 Additional Handala or Iran-aligned claims against U.S. water/energy, especially Texas/Gulf Coast [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch for new Handala (or affiliated proxy) claims against U.S. water or energy utilities, consistent with the group's documented claim-then-escalate pattern following the Stryker and Cal Water precedents.
- Would confirm the campaign is expanding geographically and/or escalating in severity rather than remaining a single contained incident.
- Tied to: PIR 1, nation-state and proxy targeting of Texas critical infrastructure.

PIR 3 / I&W 3 U.S.-Iran framework agreement and Lebanon front status [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch for whether a U.S.-Iran framework agreement is actually signed, and whether the Lebanon/Hezbollah front continues or de-escalates.
- An unsigned or collapsed agreement, or continued Israel-Hezbollah fighting, sustains proxy retaliation incentive independent of the main negotiation.
- Tied to: PIR 3 and PIR 7, escalation indicators and geopolitical-cyber acceleration.

PIR 6 / I&W 4 New CISA/FBI/WaterISAC advisory referencing the Cal Water incident or water-sector campaign [*→ Sustained*]

- Watch for a federal advisory specifically addressing the Cal Water incident or a broader Iran-aligned water-sector retaliation campaign (none issued as of 13 June).
- Would confirm federal situational awareness is treating this as a sector-wide concern, not an isolated incident, and may carry specific Texas-relevant guidance.
- Tied to: PIR 6, executive decision-relevant warning.

PIR 4 / I&W 5 JDY/China-nexus scanning against Texas-relevant DIB or edge infrastructure [*→ Sustained*]

- Watch for reporting that JDY-linked scanning has expanded beyond military/DIB-associated networks into energy, finance, or healthcare IP space, or that it has targeted newly disclosed CVEs affecting Texas-relevant DIB or edge infrastructure.
- Would upgrade the China item from a secondary DIB-framed implication to a Texas cross-sector concern.
- Tied to: PIR 4, defense-industrial-base and technology-sector targeting.

Section VI

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk

Whether to treat IT/operational-support segmentation (the Cal Water attack path) and OT exposure (AA26-097A) as an active-campaign priority this week, given a confirmed proxy operation has already succeeded against a comparable utility.

Owner	CISO + COO/OT operations lead, with board risk-committee visibility.
Consequence of delay	A Texas water or energy operator with a similar GPS/survey-to-billing segmentation gap becomes the next confirmed Handala target; an unaddressed AA26-097A PLC exposure becomes an OT-disruption event during ERCOT summer peak.
Action this week	Audit segmentation between field-operations/GPS-survey networks and customer-facing IT/billing systems; confirm no internet-exposed Rockwell/Allen-Bradley PLCs and review HMI/SCADA displays for anomalies (AA26-097A); patch Check Point CVE-2026-50751, validate IKEv1 exposure, review VPN logs to early May, rotate credentials; verify DDoS mitigation is current given the now-substantiated FINRA Iran warning.
Record to preserve	Segmentation audit results; AA26-097A review/remediation status; Check Point patch and VPN log-review records; DDoS readiness confirmation; Cal Water incident tracked as an external precedent for board briefing; board notification timestamp and decision.

Section VII

Actions This Week

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Audit: Map segmentation between field-operations/GPS-survey networks and customer-facing IT/billing systems — the exact pivot path Handala used against Cal Water.

Confirm: No internet-exposed Rockwell/Allen-Bradley PLCs per AA26-097A; review HMI/SCADA displays and project files for anomalies.

Patch: Check Point CVE-2026-50751 — validate IKEv1 exposure, review VPN logs back to early May, rotate credentials.

Verify: DDoS mitigation readiness, given FINRA's now-substantiated warning on Iranian disruptive-operations capability and intent.

Section VIII

Prior Judgment Tracker

Prior judgment	ATB-2026-13 assessed the convergence of an eight-agency federal advisory on automatic tank gauge exploitation across U.S. fuel infrastructure with ERCOT's disclosure of voltage ride-through test failures entering peak summer demand as the dominant cross-sector risk.
Current status	Carried forward as standing context — ERCOT summer-peak fragility continues to compound the consequence of any OT disruption — but superseded as this week's dominant theme by the confirmed Iran-aligned retaliatory campaign.

What changed	Handala's confirmed access to California Water Service is the first evidenced instance of the Iran-retaliation pattern previously assessed as anticipated in prior issues — the campaign is now demonstrated, not projected.
Confidence movement	Confidence that Iran-aligned retaliatory cyber activity is occurring increased from Moderate-to-High (anticipated) to High (confirmed). Confidence in escalation toward OT disruption or extension to Texas-specific targets remains Moderate.
Next indicator	Cal Water investigation findings confirming or denying OT/ICS access, an additional Handala claim against a U.S. water or energy operator (especially Gulf Coast), or a new federal advisory referencing this campaign would raise escalation posture.

Section IX — Sourcing

Open Source Basis

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-14 — COVERAGE WEEK 7–13 JUNE 2026 AND CONTINUING BASELINE

VICTIM STATEMENT

California Water Service — Statement on Handala Breach Claim

yahoo.com/news/us/articles/iranian-hacker-group-alleges-breached-162406352.html

12 June 2026. Cal Water director of communications states preliminary IT/OT scan found no compromise to production or delivery systems; investigation ongoing. Used for Executive Warning, Dominant Judgment, KJ-1, and What Changed.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA/FBI/NSA/EPA — Advisory AA26-097A: Iranian-Affiliated Cyber Actors Exploit PLCs Across U.S. Critical Infrastructure

cisa.gov/news-events/cybersecurity-advisories/aa26-097a

Published 7 April 2026. Standing baseline for Iranian OT targeting of Rockwell/Allen-Bradley PLCs across energy, water, and government sectors. Used for Dominant Judgment, KJ-2, and Cross-Sector Cascade (Energy/Water).

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA — Known Exploited Vulnerabilities Catalog (CVE-2026-50751)

cisa.gov/known-exploited-vulnerabilities-catalog

Added 8 June 2026. Check Point Security Gateway IKEv1 improper-authentication vulnerability. Used for What Changed and Cross-Sector Cascade (Finance).

REGULATORY / INDUSTRY ALERT

FINRA — Cybersecurity Alert: Heightened Threats from Iranian Cyber Actors

finra.org/rules-guidance/guidance/cybersecurity-alert-heightened-threats-iranian-cyber-actors

Standing alert. Warns member firms of Iranian state-sponsored and aligned actors' capability and intent for disruptive operations during heightened tension. Used for Cross-Sector Cascade (Finance).

VENDOR PRIMARY RESEARCH

Lumen Black Lotus Labs — Expanded JDY IoT and SOHO Botnet Enables Rapid Vulnerability Exploitation

lumen.com/blog/en-us/expanded-idy-iot-and-soho-botnet-enables-rapid-vulnerability-exploitation

Published 10 June 2026. Primary vendor research on China-nexus JDY botnet scaling. Used as a DIB-relevant implication (KJ-3), not a general Texas cross-sector claim — the report does not name energy, finance, or healthcare as targeted sectors.

INDEPENDENT TECHNICAL ANALYSIS

SecurityWeek / Rescana / SecurityAffairs — Handala Cal Water Breach Analysis

securityweek.com/iranian-cyber-group-handala-claims-cal-water-hack

12–13 June 2026. Independent (Dataminr) technical analysis confirming access scope limited to GPS-correction server and billing database, with Chico district confirmed as the access point. Used for Dominant Judgment and KJ-1.

ATTRIBUTION CONTEXT

Handala Public Claim — “From Sirik to California”

breachnews.com/cyber-attacks/handala-claims-cyberattack-on-california-water-infrastructure

12 June 2026. Group’s own framing and Stuxnet reference, plus threat of further action. Treated as actor self-reporting, not independently verified beyond the technical scope confirmed by Dataminr/Cal Water. Used for Dominant Judgment.

GEOPOLITICAL / WIRE

RFE/RL — U.S.-Iran Framework Agreement and Lebanon Front Status

rferl.org/a/iran-war-us-hormuz-oil-blockade-gulf-israel/33640284.html

13–14 June 2026. Used for What Changed (framework agreement / Lebanon status) and Geopolitical Driver.

VENDOR-DERIVED (MODERATE CONFIDENCE)

CrowdStrike / Proofpoint reporting (via industry press) — DPRK Famous Chollima & UNK_DeadDrop

9–11 June 2026, as relayed in operator-curated source list. Vendor-derived figures on DPRK fake-IT-worker and developer-phishing operations. Used for Cross-Sector Cascade (Healthcare/DIB/AI) at moderate confidence; not independently verified against primary vendor reports this cycle.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: An Iran-aligned proxy, Handala, executed and publicly confirmed a retaliatory cyber operation against California Water Service on 11–12 June, accessing a GPS-correction network and customer billing database in explicit retaliation for U.S. strikes on Iranian water infrastructure; Cal Water found no IT/OT compromise as investigation continues. Separately, a possible U.S.-Iran framework agreement is pending while the Lebanon front remains active; China-linked JDY reconnaissance has doubled since 2024 with a military/DIB focus; and CISA added an actively exploited Check Point VPN flaw to its KEV catalog. **WHO:** Handala (publicly pro-Palestinian hacktivist persona, widely assessed as Iran-backed Void Manticore/MOIS) defines this week’s confirmed evidence base. AA26-097A’s Iranian-affiliated APT remains the standing OT-disruption reference threat. China-nexus Volt Typhoon (via JDY) remains the DIB-relevant reconnaissance reference threat. DPRK Famous Chollima/UNK_DeadDrop remain a carried-forward, vendor-derived access-governance risk. **WHY:** Handala’s operation demonstrates that Iran-aligned proxy retaliation operates on its own timeline, triggered by specific kinetic events rather than the overall U.S.-Iran negotiation status. The confirmed attack chain (survey/GPS network → billing system) is a segmentation failure pattern broadly replicable across U.S. water and energy utilities, including in Texas. **WHAT NEXT:** Texas Gulf Coast energy and water operators should treat the Cal Water attack chain as a same-week audit item, not a future planning exercise. The immediate task is to find the equivalent pivot path in your own environment before Handala — or a similar proxy — finds it first. *A confirmed attack against a comparable utility is not a warning anymore. It is the test case.*

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